

Fascination of plants

Planten zijn overal. Ze voorzien ons van voedsel, houden ecosystemen in stand en geven vorm aan de wereld waarin we leven. Toch vindt plantenonderzoek meestal plaats achter gesloten deuren van laboratoria en delen wij, de plantenonderzoekers, onze bevindingen niet vaak met het grote publiek. Waarom?

Heeft het te maken met het soort onderzoek? Met de manier waarop het publiek ernaar kijkt? Of ligt het misschien ingewikkelder? Daar lijkt het in ieder geval wel op. Bovendien is het hoofddoel van plantenonderzoek het vergaren van kennis. Kan plantenonderzoek ook andere doelen dienen?

Op deze acht posters kun je enkele antwoorden van onderzoekers en studenten van de Universiteit Utrecht op deze vragen bekijken, ingedeeld in rubrieken over de impact van hun onderzoek, toekomstperspectieven, uitdagingen waarmee ze te maken hebben gehad bij het communiceren over wetenschap, en eerdere ervaringen op dit gebied. Denk tijdens je bezoek aan deze tentoonstelling na of je het met hen eens bent. Rechtsonder op elke poster staat een QR-code. Scan deze en deel je mening met ons. Om de Nederlandse versie van de posters te lezen, kun je de QR-code aan de linkerkant scannen.

Kom op 12 juni van 11:45 tot 14:00 langs om samen met ons jullie reacties te bespreken, te luisteren naar wetenschappers die met hun onderzoek een verschil hebben gemaakt voor de samenleving en te genieten van prachtige wetenschappelijke foto's die door enkele van onze onderzoekers zijn gemaakt. Scan de QR-codes voor meer informatie over hoe je mee kunt doen.

Plants are everywhere. They feed us, sustain ecosystems, and shape the world we live in. Yet plant research tends to happen quietly behind laboratory doors, and we, the plant researchers, don't often share it with the public. Why?

Does it have to do with the type of research? With the public's perception? Or maybe it is more complex? It certainly seems to be. Moreover, the main aim of plant research is to fulfil the goal of generating knowledge. Can plant research also have other purposes?

In these eight posters, you can look at some of Utrecht University's researchers' and students' answers to these questions, divided into sections referring to the impact of their research, future perspectives, challenges they have faced doing science communication, and previous experiences on this topic. As you read through the exhibition, ponder if you share the same opinions. At the bottom right corner of every poster, there is a QR code. Please, scan it and share your thoughts with us. To read the Dutch version of the posters, you can scan the QR code on the left.

On the 12th of June, from 11:45 to 14:00, join us as we discuss all of your responses, as well as hear from scientists who have had an impact on society with their research, and admire some beautiful scientific images taken by some of our researchers. More information on how to join in the QR codes.

Veel plezier bij de expositie.
Enjoy the exhibition.



MSc student Karl Strube

In my Master's thesis I study how to create a tomato flower, and eventually a full tomato fruit, without the whole tomato plant. This is done by using a combination of certain plant hormones to trick plant stem cells into differentiating into flowers, skipping the normal plant development process. This is our version of lab-grown meat, but for tomatoes.

ON THE IMPACT

This project will eventually reduce electricity and heating costs, production time and space for tomato growth. Our focus is still quite academic, but our goal is to reach this stage in the near future.



Tomato flower (in-vitro). This flower is still in the development stage, so it still has to form the regular flower shape.

ON PREVIOUS EXPERIENCES

I'm a tour guide at the Botanic Gardens, and I really enjoy it. I like to design my own tours because I get to tell great stories about some of the plants.

The most rewarding element so far has been when people on the tours mentioned that they had no prior interest in plants and left with a different perspective.

ON THE CHALLENGES

I think people enjoy themselves more during the tours if they are more interactive. When I let people touch or smell the plants, or when I point out certain structures and how they are different between plants, that is what they like. I am also careful to avoid scientific language that does not have to be there.



Tomato fruit (in-vitro). Once the flower has developed, we can pollinate and grow full tomatoes.

